Andrej Karpathy Joins Anthropic to Lead AI-Assisted Pretraining Research

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Andrej Karpathy, co-founder of OpenAI and former director of AI at Tesla, joined Anthropic on May 19 to work on pretraining, the large-scale, compute-intensive training phase that gives Claude its core knowledge and capabilities. He joins under team lead Nick Joseph and will build a new group focused on using Claude itself to accelerate pretraining research. "I think the next few years at the frontier of LLMs will be especially formative," Karpathy wrote on X.

He holds a PhD in computer science from Stanford, led Tesla's Full Self-Driving vision system from 2017 to 2022, returned briefly to OpenAI, and most recently founded Eureka Labs, an AI education startup. He remains "deeply passionate about education" and plans to return to it eventually.

Karpathy is one of the few researchers who bridges LLM theory and large-scale training practice. His hire signals Anthropic sees AI-assisted research, not just raw compute, as the way to stay competitive with OpenAI and Google. The move came the same week Anthropic acquired Stainless, the company behind every official Anthropic SDK. Elon Musk once called Karpathy "arguably the #2 guy in the world in computer vision," per emails shown at the Musk v. Altman trial that concluded the day before.

The talent race at the frontier now looks like a three-body problem. OpenAI, Google, and Anthropic are pulling researchers from each other and from adjacent companies like Tesla and xAI. Hiring Karpathy specifically to build an AI-for-AI-research team suggests the next competitive edge comes from recursive improvement in the training process itself, not from stacking more GPUs.

Read More: AI This Week: Erdős Conjecture, Karpathy, Gemini 3.5, OpenAI IPO

Sources:

- Anthropic Hires Karpathy (CNBC)
- Karpathy Joins Anthropic's Pre-Training Team (TechCrunch)
- Former Tesla AI Boss Joins Anthropic (The Verge)
- Karpathy Announcement on X

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